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【メール原文】

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another break in the trump-zelenskyy relationship. more iran fighting coming. and us midterms.

us, ukraine, russia

a challenging week for ukrainian president volodymyr zelenskyy. ever since the blow up at the white house over a year ago, zelenskyy has made it a priority to engage constructively, both publicly and privately, with president trump. despite continual tension over the united states ending direct financial support, being skeptical about expanded sanctions, and pressuring ukraine to offer expanded concessions in service of a ceasefire, anytime you spoke recently with ukrainian leaders about trump, the response was some version of "we're good with the americans."

but over the past month, the united states has increased pressure on ukraine in a time of growing domestic unrest for zelenskyy politically and militarily—in marked contrast to the trump administration's engagement with putin (who has been enticed with business deals, invited to the g20 summit in miami, and never directly criticized)—a dynamic that has been met with incredulity from the ukrainians. the proximate cause of the blow up was ukraine's repeated attacks on refineries, many deep inside russian territory. russia has proved incapable of defending against the attacks, and the ukrainians don't need any help from the americans for targeting (us intelligence is essential for mobile targets—principally missiles and other military capabilities; but for fixed infrastructure ukraine can act independently).

trump was facing domestic political pressure with record-level diesel prices, having already placed significant pressure on europe to restrict purchasing from the united states or else threatening to impose his own export ban, and so the issue was top of mind. the us president accordingly made a number of entreaties to zelenskyy—first through steve witkoff and jared kushner, then directly on two private calls, and then publicly—and the ukrainian president refused to stop the refinery attacks.

trump was incensed. from his perspective, the united states is still providing significant support to ukraine in the war: with much of ukraine's external weapons provided (though not paid for) by the americans; ongoing critical intelligence in helping ukraine defend itself, by tracking incoming russian missiles and identifying mobile missile launchers to strike; and the pentagon standing up starshield for offensive and defensive drone operations on ukraine's territory.

zelenskyy wasn't much happier. the ukrainian president sees the europeans now providing all the funding for the war and the americans profiting from it (by selling weapons). recent american weapons support has notably not included adequate interceptors or patriot missiles (which the us military is running low on), while president trump announced and then slow walked licenses for the ukrainians to build their own patriots. meanwhile, russia has stepped up attacks on ukrainian critical infrastructure across the country, as well as a dramatic step up in targeting civilians directly—the latter, which ukraine has restrained itself from doing—without facing any blowback from president trump.

and so trump decided to cut a deal with putin directly for diesel supplies. and shortly thereafter announced that there was a ceasefire on energy targets, agreed to by both countries, and then unilaterally suspended the recently passed (and trump signed) graham sanctions package. as with trump's earlier calls for an unconditional ceasefire (which zelenskyy accepted, expecting and receiving swift rejection from putin), zelenskyy said he hadn't been contacted on the ceasefire but agreed to it and, while waiting on the russians, ordered a suspension of refinery attacks. but while putin had indeed agreed on the diesel (it was a unilateral giveaway from the americans, undermining ukraine and increasing russia's leverage with third parties), he ignored the ceasefire, continuing attacks against ukrainian energy targets later that day.

at which point zelenskyy criticized trump in unprecedented fashion—saying he was "betrayed" by the american president. trump in return said it was time for the ukrainian president to step down (a call quickly echoed by spacex owner elon musk), and the white house ordered the pentagon to throttle the starshield service. ukraine in turn restarted attacks on russia's refineries.

the implications are twofold. first, on the ukraine war. the united states is increasingly leaning toward a militarily neutral position in the war, with political alignment toward putin. trump is looking to reengage with the russian president irrespective of escalation in the ukraine war, while supporting zelenskyy's ouster (also a core putin demand). i don't see the americans suspending purl (the prioritised ukraine requirements list), which allows the europeans to buy us weapons for ukraine—there's too much money in it for american firms. but ongoing direct support for ukraine is now open to revision, as is the potential for the americans returning to business as usual with putin.

second, on the transatlantic alliance. all of trump's decisions around zelenskyy and putin over the past week have been made unilaterally, absent consultations with nato allies providing the lion's share of support for ukraine. indeed, trump's been more interested in engaging with china on russia of late (suggesting in his last summit meeting with xi that the three leaders meet together at the upcoming g20 summit in miami this december; the chinese are considering it). meanwhile, russia is intensifying hybrid attacks against european governments they perceive as adversarial (france, germany, poland, baltics, nordics, etc), with no direct condemnation from the united states. the europeans are trying to increase their own capabilities to respond against russia (with france already engaging in more robust counterespionage activities, germany changing their constitution to allow it to engage in covert actions against russia, and the eu working toward the possible seizure of frozen russian assets), but the europeans are limited in an environment where they can't expect president trump to stand by their defense in the event of a sudden escalation. further, growing pressure from russia absent american support provides more space for pro-russian far-right parties across the continent, arguing to end support for ukraine and normalize russia relations (not to mention energy ties and broader trade). that's particularly true of france, where one of russia's most stalwart enemies has a coin flip chance of flipping into their camp if marine le pen wins the presidency in 2027.

on both fronts, putin has high incentive to escalate while trump retains control of the presidency with limited republican pushback.

us - iran

in contrast, there remain harder constraints on both fronts of the iran war. the iranians are hitting more ships traveling through the strait of hormuz...and the united states' response has been striking iranian ships (fishing vessels) that are doing the spotting for the drone and missile launchers. the houthis are hitting saudi ships as well as airports and even saudi aramco headquarters, and saudi arabia is all in on

the war against them (with direct support from turkey and pakistan), but the americans have stayed out.

it now looks more likely than not that the united states is going to order significant military strikes against iran...after the midterms. a second aircraft carrier group (the george bush) has just returned to the theater after a rest stop in southeast asia; a third will arrive shortly. the united states has taken its bombers out of the united kingdom given a local terrorist threat, but can still target using b1s and b2s based in the united states.

the intention is something short and substantial—meaningful enough to cause damage and offer another opportunity for trump to "declare victory," not so substantial that the iranians engage in dramatic escalation that puts the gulf states in existential risk (though american tolerance for strikes against the gulf states is higher than the gulf would like...). the principal scenario is under a week, with strikes against military assets (destroying ballistic missiles and drone stockpiles that have been buried and dug out, with larger ordinance; remaining military bases, etc); strikes against nuclear sites (which would cause some meaningful damage, and allow president trump to lean into the "never any nuclear weapons" framing that he continues to focus on); and potentially some critical infrastructure (gas infrastructure, bridges, rail, and the like), although this latter is heavily contested within the trump administration.

not on the military program: 1) iran's leadership, since the initial assassinations have already proved a challenge for engaging with the iranian government. 2) oil, because iranian oil is blockaded and the trump administration wants to preserve the option for venezuela type deals if and when a new iranian government emerges. and 3) major critical infrastructure, like the electricity grid, desalination plants, etc, because the united states is hoping to minimize the blowback attacks from iran against gulf state infrastructure (which they haven't engaged in for months).

the intention is that the americans show that they still have unfettered ability to deter iran from developing threshold nuclear capabilities and taking over the strait of hormuz. the problem, as the generals like to say: the enemy gets a vote. and it's still very hard to see iran changing its negotiating position on the back of these (comparatively restrained) strikes. especially if the intention remains giving trump a way to say he won and got out...the iranian posture will be maintain a hardline, themselves declare victory, and engage in negotiations in the hopes of better long-term outcome with gulf states that no longer feel like they can rely on the americans.

us elections

us elections are only two weeks away (can you believe it?). and the core issues are pretty much baked in—with a blended approval rating of some 37%, president trump stands at his most unpopular of either of his two administrations. he's particularly underwater on the economy, with the latest inflation numbers only going up—and given an iran war that's now closing in on nine months of fighting with no end in sight, and trump viewed as more interested in self-dealing and enrichment than the wellbeing of average americans—trump is seen as directly responsible for the downturn.

trump is on the campaign trail, with rally after rally, but at this point that's as much about asserting continued control of the republican party as it is attempting to impact key races (especially since much of the travel is to deep red states where there's no possibility of a swing). republican insiders have given up on retaining the house; it now looks more likely than not that democrats take the senate as well—with the present expected outcome of a 52-54 seat democratic majority. some of those races remain quite close, so that's not a confident call (and nearly all the polls and prediction markets reflect

that); but it's becoming more so. at this point, i'd put my thumb on expectations of a blue wave, mostly because midterm turnout is about higher conviction voters, and while trump has maintained most of his maga base, the level of enthusiasm for him as candidate among those voters has decreased precipitously.

i put no stock in the potential for trump to use extralegal means to change outcomes. it's not been his focus, he's too undisciplined to suddenly change that, and he ultimately doesn't see the midterms as about him. yes, he'll probably claim they're fake/rigged (even though republicans will have been in charge of the key mechanisms of electoral oversight); but even there without enthusiasm—it's nothing like 2020, when trump personally had to hand over power to biden. from his perspective, he's not handing over anything (and indeed, though it's not his preference, there's part of his personality that will enjoy having a foil and someone else to blame for things).

so what then? trump governs by executive order. it's not as if he relies on the legislature for much. but still, i expect despite all his uniqueness, trump becomes more of a lame duck (and more quickly) than people believe. a few reasons: 1) i don't buy the "trump will become even more unhinged" line. i challenge people to explain what they mean by that; it's not as if the last two years of trump have been an exercise of restraint. constraints have come from domestic pushback...and that's only going to intensify. indeed, if he announces things that are even more off the rails (say, an order to arrest opponents unlawfully; or to stir up jan 6 style violence), it gives republicans looking for a reason to jump more incentive to do so. 2) trump's health. he's 80 and losing mental coherence. fox news already more frequently bolts from his rallies mid-sentence; fewer local leaders want to campaign with him. most republicans expect to have substantially longer careers than the president, and they don't want to go down with the ship. that means a substantial egress from cabinet, with more people willing to act the way they did after the first term, with more consequence—and trump will be much angrier and more vindictive against former employees turned rogue than democrats. 3) the media cycle. a democratic house and senate will be an onslaught of investigations. not directly consequential, to be sure, but they'll drive the headlines and the narrative, so trump will be reacting to news much more than he's causing it. 4) trump's focus. he continues to spend an inordinate amount of time on making money for him and his family, and remaking washington dc (physically)/putting his name on things. and while i wouldn't suggest that's irrelevant, given the precedents being set for the exercise of presidential power, it's nonetheless much less important than, say, two years focused on remaking executive authority. and while it should be clear, i'm going to say it anyway: 5) there's no chance of a trump third term (white house gift shop merch notwithstanding).

i thought it was peak trump on the global stage back in late spring...but i wasn't ready to say that about the domestic environment. that's about to change with the midterm elections. still plenty of uncertainty and dysfunction, but not like the first two years.

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some very sad news. moose, my sturdy, courageous and surprisingly loveable norfolk terrier, is no longer with us. moose loved food...unless there was a tennis ball on offer. you have to respect that. he hated squirrels, bicycles (which is how i expect to die in nyc) and, i suspect, capital letters. he refused to go to martha's vineyard. moose made it to sixteen and the spirit was still willing—he walked up a flight of stairs in his last hour—alas the body just couldn't handle more. life, not to mention my social media feed, stands less joyful.

we can all use a little moose.

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